SPORTS

DASHING THROUGH THE SNOW

Against all odds, Bhavani T.N. is scripting history for India and herself in cross-country skiing

Last month, Bhavani T.N. and her coach, Gianluca, evaluated her performance at the Raiffeisen Langlauf Cup in Dobbiaco, Italy. Her timing of 18 minutes and 3 seconds over the 5-km cross-country skiing course had pleased both. It was a good start to their nascent, month-long partnership, an indicator of their efforts heading in the right direction.

The next minute, the loudspeaker announced: 'Silver…Bhavani T.N., India.' The lunch abandoned, she ran to the presentation area in disbelief. "I told them there had been some mistake. But they simply asked me to get on the podium," Bhavani recalls. The silver was historic—the first international medal for an Indian woman in the discipline. And it came against all odds, given that Bhavani took to the sport just three years ago.

In fact, until 2014, Bhavani had never seen snow. It was only after she visited Manali for a basic mountaineering course that she had her first brush with altitude. There was an instant connection and, over the next few years, she trained to be a mountaineer, even working as an instructor at the Himalayan Mountaineering Institute in Darjeeling.

She first tried alpine skiing in 2017, but it wasn't until she drew inspiration from the underdog movie *Eddie the Eagle*—a sports biopic of British skier and Olympian Michael Edwards—that she first thought of getting trained the following year. "Competition was never on my mind. It was just another skill to help me in mountaineering. But along the way, I realised I was pretty good at it," she recalls.

After the basic, intermediate and advanced skiing courses, she picked up her ski instruction certification in New Zealand and soon found employment at the Jawahar Institute of Mountaineering and Winter Sports in Gulmarg. It was there that she first picked up cross-country



"Competition was never on my mind. It was just another skill to help me in mountaineering," says **BHAVANI**